

The Morning Briefing

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US POLITICS · JUDICIARY · ISRAEL & THE MIDDLE EAST · ROME & THE VATICAN · WORLD · RESEARCH & LONG READS

LEAD STORY — ISRAEL & THE MIDDLE EAST

Netanyahu Rejects Gaza Disarmament Roadmap as Houthis Strike Saudi Refinery and CENTCOM Chief Huddles With IDF

Three fronts moved at once over the weekend: Netanyahu disowned the Board of Peace's 15-point Gaza plan and reversed an approved IDF pullback near Rafah; a Houthi drone hit Saudi Aramco's Jazan refinery days after Riyadh signed a new defense pact; and the top US general in the region met Israel's military chief as Washington and Tehran traded conciliatory signals.

US POLITICS

Collins-Murray Deal Buys the Government Five More Weeks

Senate Appropriations leaders Susan Collins (R-ME) and Patty Murray (D-WA) struck a stopgap funding deal that keeps the government open through Dec. 11, averting a shutdown when current funding lapses Oct. 1. The House already passed its own version funding through Dec. 4 and left for August recess; the chambers must close a six-week gap when they return in September. Collins says the bill avoids "poison pills" but attaches SNAP, WIC, disaster-relief, and national-security provisions.

WHY IT MATTERS

A five-week gap between the House and Senate end dates is exactly the kind of seam that produced this year's two earlier shutdowns. Expect this to resurface hard in September.

Source: **Senate Appropriations Committee** appropriations.senate.gov · **NBC News** nbcnews.com

Trump Signs New Birthright Citizenship Order, Weeks After Losing at the Court

President Trump signed new executive orders narrowing birthright citizenship, weeks after the Supreme Court's June ruling struck down his original attempt and reaffirmed the 14th Amendment's citizenship guarantee. Alan Dershowitz called the new order "absolutely" constitutional; most originalist scholars, including conservative Berkeley law professor John Yoo, disagree.

WHY IT MATTERS

This is a direct rerun of a fight the administration already lost 6-3 at the Court in June. The legal theory shifted at the margins, not the core claim. Full scholarly debate in Research & Long Reads.

Source: **NPR** npr.org

SCOTUS & THE JUDICIARY

Appeals Court Blocks Trump's \$400 Million Ballroom, Sets Up Supreme Court Fight

A divided D.C. Circuit panel upheld an injunction blocking Trump's \$400 million White House ballroom project, ruling that "each President is a temporary tenant, not the owner, of the White House" and cannot remake it without congressional approval. The suit was brought by the National Trust for Historic Preservation after the administration demolished the East Wing without authorization. The panel stayed its own order two weeks so the administration can appeal; Trump says he will take it straight to the Supreme Court.

ANALYTICAL READ

This is a live separation-of-powers case dressed up as a construction dispute — the real question is how much

unilateral control a president has over federal property absent Congress. Worth tracking as precedent regardless of how the ballroom itself turns out.

Source: **NBC News** nbcnews.com · **Washington Post** washingtonpost.com

The Term in Review: A Court at a New Approval Low

The Court's June docket included the 6-3 birthright citizenship ruling (Roberts writing for the majority), a ruling letting states bar transgender athletes from girls' school sports (Kavanaugh writing), and a decision striking down FECA limits on coordinated party campaign spending. The Court's public approval rating hit a new low afterward.

Source: **NPR** npr.org

Netanyahu: Israel "Rejects" the Board of Peace's Gaza Roadmap

Netanyahu said Israel "rejects" the Board of Peace's 15-point Gaza disarmament roadmap, pushing back on reports that Israel had accepted it, and said Israel will not withdraw from its current lines "until Hamas is completely disarmed." Separately, reporting indicates Netanyahu personally approved an IDF pullout from three areas near Rafah before reversing course days later.

ANALYTICAL READ

The reversal is the tell. A security rationale doesn't usually get approved and then walked back within days — that pattern looks more like a prime minister responding to further-right coalition pressure than to a coherent military assessment. An August poll found 62 percent of Israelis doubt Netanyahu's promised "total victory" will ever arrive, and he heads into an October election trailing in early seat projections. A collapsed disarmament plan removes pressure for a full withdrawal his coalition doesn't want to make anyway. Treat the "security" framing as one input among several, not the whole explanation.

Source: **The Jerusalem Post** jpost.com · **Times of Israel** timesofisrael.com

CENTCOM Chief Meets Zamir Amid Dual-Track Iran Diplomacy

CENTCOM commander Adm. Brad Cooper visited Israel Aug. 8, meeting IDF Chief of Staff Eyal Zamir and senior officers on the "multi-front situation," after stops in Bahrain and the UAE. The visit came alongside notably upbeat signals from Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian and US Vice President JD Vance about a possible new ceasefire framework.

ANALYTICAL READ

Washington is running two tracks at once — military reassurance to Israel and quiet diplomatic overture to

Tehran. That divergence matters: Netanyahu has separately hinted he could act unilaterally against Iran even as the US and Iran head toward an interim arrangement. A unilateral Israeli strike would blow up a US-brokered deal Washington has more to gain from than Jerusalem does.

Source: **Times of Israel** timesofisrael.com

Houthi Drone Hits Saudi Aramco Refinery Days After Defense Pact

Yemen's Houthis claimed a drone attack on Saudi Aramco's Jazan refinery (400,000 barrels/day capacity) early Aug. 9, saying it was retaliation for Saudi drone incursions into Saada and Hajjah. Saudi authorities extinguished the fire; no injuries were reported. The strike came shortly after Saudi Arabia signed a new defense pact, and the Houthis also claimed a separate operation against Saudi-aligned forces near Mocha.

ANALYTICAL READ

An Iran-aligned militia hitting Saudi oil infrastructure right after Riyadh formalizes a defense arrangement looks like a message about the cost of that alignment, not a random skirmish. Worth watching whether Tehran distances itself from the timing or lets the ambiguity stand — that is usually how deniable pressure campaigns work.

Source: **NBC News** nbcnews.com · **Al Jazeera** aljazeera.com

Trump: US "Low-Keying" Iran, Betting on Economic Pressure

Trump said the US is "low-keying" its approach to Iran, favoring continued economic pressure over military escalation, and said Iran "is in very bad shape" financially. Iran says no direct talks resume until the US honors the June interim agreement.

Source: **CNN** cnn.com

ITALY, ROME & THE VATICAN

Pope Appeals for Ukraine and Sudan: "War Only Begets More War"

Pope Leo XIV used his Aug. 9 Angelus to appeal for peace in Ukraine and Sudan:

"Distressing reports continue to arrive of innocent people being killed and injured in Ukraine and Russia... these incidents are occurring one after another; indeed, they are multiplying, resulting in ever-increasing numbers of civilian victims, including children." — "War only begets more war and causes immense suffering."

He renewed his call for both sides to respect humanitarian law and halt attacks on civilian targets.

Source: **Vatican.va (official text)** vatican.va · **Crux** cruxnow.com

Leo XIV's August: Assisi, San Marino, and the Vatican II Catechesis

After resting in Castel Gandolfo through July, Leo XIV resumed a full public schedule in August: he celebrated Mass in Assisi on Aug. 6 for the feast of the Transfiguration, is holding weekly general audiences again (his ongoing

catechesis series works through the documents of the Second Vatican Council, most recently Lumen Gentium's teaching on the Church as mystery), and will make a pastoral visit to San Marino on Aug. 22 before celebrating Mass in Rimini for the 47th Meeting for Friendship Among Peoples. His prayer intention for August is evangelization in the city.

Source: **America Magazine** americamagazine.org · **Catholic Herald** thecatholicherald.com · **EWTN** ewtnnews.com

Meloni Thanks Carabinieri Injured in No TAV Clashes

Prime Minister Giorgia Meloni visited the Salvo D'Acquisto Carabinieri barracks on Aug. 4 with the Carabinieri commander general, meeting officers injured during the violent No TAV clashes in Val di Susa on July 25, and thanked them on behalf of the government for their "professionalism, bravery and sense of duty."

Source: **Governo.it (official)** governo.it

WORLD NEWS

Tehran Reads Saudi-Pakistan-Turkey Pact as a Message

Iran's government said the new Saudi-Pakistan-Turkey defense arrangement reflects a "change in perception" toward the US regionally — a signal Tehran is watching Gulf-Sunni alignment shifts closely as its own talks with Washington continue in parallel.

Source: **Times of Israel** [timesofisrael.com](https://www.timesofisrael.com)

Ukraine-Russia Civilian Toll Keeps Climbing

Civilian casualties in the Russia-Ukraine war continue to climb on both sides, per the Pope's Aug. 9 remarks above; no ceasefire framework is currently on the table.

RESEARCH & LONG READS

Birthright Citizenship Splits the Right's Legal Scholars

Trump's new executive order has reopened a genuine split among conservative legal scholars. Kurt Lash and Ilan Wurman separately argue the 14th Amendment's original meaning is narrower than the conventional reading — Lash would exclude children of parents unlawfully present, Wurman would limit the guarantee to children of lawful permanent residents. Conservative scholar John Yoo calls both arguments too "tortured" and has made what he calls the originalist case for the traditional, broad reading, a position most scholars across the spectrum share. A Cornell Law Review piece goes further, arguing the narrow-reading scholars are constructing an ahistorical, revisionist account of "jurisdiction" to reach a predetermined result. A useful test case in how originalism functions as method versus how it sometimes gets bent toward outcome.

Read: **National Affairs (Yoo)** nationalaffairs.com · **Cornell Law Review** publications.lawschool.cornell.edu · **SCOTUSblog** scotusblog.com

Vatican II and the Case for Reasoned Faith

Catholic Apologetics and the New Evangelization (Church Life Journal, Notre Dame) argues that Vatican II's approach to apologetics does not abandon reasoned argument for doctrine in favor of bare faith claims — it holds that reason, common human experience, and the historical reliability of the Gospel accounts are meant to support and undergird the faith, not stand opposed to it. Directly relevant background for the Second Vatican Council catechesis Leo XIV is currently working through at his Wednesday audiences.

Read: **Church Life Journal** churchlifejournal.nd.edu